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Brought back together by tribute show for long-gone venue in Arlington Heights, suburban garage rockers prepare for their first headlining gig since the 1960s



Chicago man faces charge in UFC plot

20-year-old allegedly obstructed probe of White House threat

By Jason Meisner and Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A Chicago man has been charged with obstructing an FBI investigation into an alleged plot to attack the high-profile Ultimate Fighting Championship event hosted by President Donald Trump outside the White House earlier this month with drones and high-powered weapons. Alexander Iniguez Mercado, 20, was charged in an indictment made public Friday with one count of obstruction of justice, which carries up to 20 years in prison. He is the first Chicago-area person arrested in a sprawling investigation that has stretched from Washington to Ohio, Arkansas and California, where most defendants face far more serious counts of conspiracy and attempted murder.

The three-page indictment alleged Mercado was an administrator of messaging groups on the encrypted app Signal that included members who were apparently communicating about a violent attack planned for June 14, when Trump hosted the UFC event on the South Lawn.

According to charges filed in the case, the group began planning violence in March and eventually coalesced around a scheme to fly explosive-laden drones over the arena and deploy snipers to shoot “high-value” targets as they fled.

Seven other individuals from multiple states have been charged in connection with planning the violent attack.

The day before the event, an FBI special agent spoke with Mercado by telephone about

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THEY DIDN'T MISS A BEAT

By Chris Placek | DAILY HERALD

See **HUNS** on Page A4

Bands often break up over creative differences or personal conflicts, but in the case of The Huns, it was just the calendar: high school graduation day.

The garage rockers from the northwest suburbs went off to college and careers, and hadn't performed together in public — much less picked up a guitar, for some of them — since the late 1960s, when they were regulars on the local touring circuit of church gymnasiums, sock hops and teen dance clubs.

Then came the Oct. 15, 2025, tribute show to one of those revered, now long-gone clubs: The Cellar. The Arlington

Heights venue provided a stage for local high school bands such as The Huns and The Shadows of Knight, but also up-and-comers including The Who, Cream, The Yardbirds and Buffalo Springfield.

Backed by a house band last fall at Hey Nonny — the live music venue of this era in downtown Arlington Heights — the four original members of The Huns took the stage for a four-song set, in what was their first public performance in 56 years.

Many of those filling the 100-seat listening room were

Dave Grundhoefer, left, belts lyrics while Mark Abate plays alongside during a recent rehearsal at Rough Draft Studios in Palatine on June 12. Only standing-room general admission tickets remain for The Huns' reunion show on Aug. 1; family, friends and classmates have already purchased the reserved seats. **JOHN STARKS/DAILY HERALD**

INSIDE



NETWORK VIDEO PRODUCTIONS

Woman killed in late-night boat crash

A 26-year-old West Loop woman died in a late Thursday night boat crash near Monroe Harbor that left at least four other people seriously injured. The two recreational boats collided with each other on Lake Michigan about a mile and a half offshore around 11:45 p.m., said Jason Lach, a deputy district chief for the Chicago Fire Department, on Friday. **ChicagoLand, Page A3**

ORDER'S UP: FX's based-in-Chicago hit “The Bear” closes its final season stuck in a narrative rut. Review in **Arts & Living, Page B7**

New life for Wright house on West Side

By Bob Goldsborough
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A badly deteriorated Frank Lloyd Wright-designed single-family home on Chicago's West Side looks to have a new lease on life, as a community organization this week bought the home and plans a major renovation and reuse.

Built in 1903 and known as the J.J. Walser House, the home, at 42 N. Central Ave., has been described by architectural experts as an exemplary example of Wright's Prairie style. It's the only Wright-designed single-family home on the West Side, and, until



The J.J. Walser House was designed by Frank Lloyd Wright and is located at 42 N. Central Ave. in Chicago's Austin neighborhood.

BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

fairly recently, the same family had owned it for more than 50 years. Longtime owner Anne Teague died in 2019, and after that, the home went into foreclosure, eventually falling into the hands of the Federal National Mortgage Association, or Fannie Mae.

The home's condition has long alarmed preservationists, partic-

ularly aficionados of Wright's work. In 2025, the nonprofit group Landmarks Illinois placed the Walser House on its annual list of the 10 most endangered historic places in Illinois.

Now, the Walser House, which was listed on the National Regis-

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Death toll hits at least 920 in duel Venezuela earthquakes

By Regina Garcia Cano, Juan Pablo Arraez and Megan Janetsky
ASSOCIATED PRESS

LA GUAIRA, Venezuela — Venezuelans took the search for missing loved ones into their own hands Friday in the aftermath of back-to-

back earthquakes, citing the scarcity of government rescuers, as the human toll of the disaster climbed to at least 920 dead and more than 51,000 missing.

Citizens digging through the rubble of their homes said they have seen few state rescue teams in the areas hit hardest by the devastating

7.2 and 7.5 magnitude quakes that struck late Wednesday, despite authorities projecting an image of a robust government response.

The lack of help compounded families' desperation as the pressure to find buried survivors increased with each passing hour. The South American nation on Friday marked

nearly two days since the disaster.

Aid agencies consider the first 48 to 72 hours to be a crucial time frame to retrieve people alive, though that period increases if they have access to food and water.

Meanwhile, a broad international aid effort accelerated, with dozens of rescue teams from around the

globe arriving in Venezuela or due to arrive there soon.

“Each person saved is a miracle,” said Jorge Rodríguez, the president of the country's National Assembly. “We are not going to hide absolutely anything about the magnitude of

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